

6.2 WORD ORDER



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A starting point: basic word order

If you think about hearing or seeing a sentence, or if you think about reading a sentence that's been written down, a really obvious property is that words and morphemes come in a particular order. Indeed, the only difference between the grammatical and ungrammatical sentences we saw in [6.1](#), repeated below in (1), is that the words appear in different orders.

- (1)
- a. All grypnos are tichek.
 - b. *Grypnos tichek all are.

Fixed vs. flexible word order

The relevance of word order for grammaticality is particularly strong for a language like English, which has relatively **fixed word order**. There isn't much flexibility in English to change the order of words in a sentence, without either changing the meaning or making the sentence ungrammatical. Lots of other languages also have relatively fixed word order—among them French, Chatino, and Choktaw (and many more as well)—but lots of other languages have much more flexible word order.

Languages with relatively flexible word order include Latin, Anishinaabemowin, Kanien'kéha, and ASL, to name just a few. For users of these languages, the order of words in a sentence is often determined by style or by the topic or focus of the sentence.

What is the basic order of words in English sentences? Based on the grammatical sentences in (2) and the ungrammatical ones in (3), see if you can come up with any generalizations about where the **verb** appears in English.

- (2)
- a. Amal ate chocolate.
 - b. Beavers build dams.
 - c. Cats chase mice.
 - d. Daffodils bloom.
 - e. Eagles fly.

- (3)
- a. *Amal chocolate ate.
 - b. *Build beavers dams.
 - c. *Chase mice cats.
 - d. *Bloom daffodils.
 - e. *Fly eagles.

These sentences are all **statements**, not **questions** or **commands**: they state a fact about the world, something that could be *true* or *false*. Looking at (3b-e), and comparing them with the grammatical sentences in (2), we can make the generalization that the verb cannot be the *first* word in an English statement.

What about (3a)? In (3a) the verb isn't the first word, but the sentence is still ungrammatical. We might try to explain that by saying that the verb also can't be the *last* word in a statement—except that the verb does come last in (2d) and (2e), which are both grammatical. So a more accurate generalization would be to say that the verb in an English sentence has to come after at least one **noun**, and that it *can* be followed by a second noun, but doesn't have to be.

We could write this generalization as a kind of formula or template: the grammatical sentences in (2) have the order **N V (N)** (the parentheses around the second “N” mean that it is optional).

Another way to describe word order involves talking not just about categories like nouns and verbs, but grammatical functions like **subject** and **object**. Word order in English doesn't just require that *any* noun come before the verb, it has to be the noun that corresponds to the subject. Similarly, if the verb is a **transitive** verb with an object, the object noun must come after the verb. So even though *Chocolate ate Amal.* is a grammatical sentence of English (though with a somewhat implausible meaning), it can't express the same meaning as *Amal ate chocolate.*

If you aren't sure about terms like “subject”, “object”, and “transitive”, continue to the end of this section and

then come back and re-read the last paragraph. Even if you already feel comfortable with those terms, it's still a good idea to review the definitions given below, to make sure that you understand the terms in the same way they're used in this textbook.

Key grammatical terminology

This section reviews some key grammatical terminology that you might be familiar with from elsewhere (for example, from language classes). This vocabulary is important for describing the basic structure of phrases and sentences, and we'll use it frequently throughout this chapter.

Sentence

A sentence is a string of words that expresses a complete statement, question, or command. For statements (as opposed to questions or commands), a sentence expresses a **proposition**, something that can be *true* or *false*. A sentence is a **clause** that stands on its own as an utterance.

Clause

A clause is a constituent that includes a subject and a predicate. Some clauses occur *inside* other clauses (see **complex sentence** below), and so not all clauses are independent sentences.

Predicate

A predicate is the state, event, or activity that the sentence attributes to its **subject**.

The word “predicate” is used in two ways. Sometimes it is used to refer to a single head or word (usually a verb or an adjective), but other times it's used to describe everything in the sentence other than the subject (for example, a whole **verb phrase**). In this chapter we use it in the first sense, to refer to a word that combines with a subject and (sometimes) one or more objects.

Arguments

Arguments are phrases that correspond to the participants or actors involved in a sentence's predicate. They are typically **noun phrases**, but it's possible to have arguments of other types (usually prepositional phrases or whole clauses).

In the sentences in (3) the arguments are in **bold** and the predicate is *italicized*.

- (3)
- a. **Vanja** *loves* **chocolate**.
 - b. **The children** *gave* [**the kitten**] [**a toy**].
 - c. **Everyone** *is* *excited*.

CLASSIFYING PREDICATES

Predicates can be classified by their **transitivity**, which is the *number* of arguments they take. (This is also sometimes called the **valency** of a predicate.) The words for transitivity are based on the *number of objects* a predicate takes.

Intransitive

An intransitive predicate takes one argument (the subject); no object.

Transitive

A transitive predicate takes two arguments (subject and direct object); one object.

Ditransitive

A ditransitive predicate takes three arguments (subject, direct object, and indirect object); two objects.

CLASSIFYING ARGUMENTS

Arguments can be classified in at least two ways: their position in the sentence, and how they're related to the predicate (are they the actor, the thing acted upon, etc). For now we'll focus on the **position** of arguments, with diagnostics specific to English. Later in this chapter, in [6.10 Arguments and thematic roles](#), we'll return to classifying arguments based on their role in the event.

Subject

Subjects almost always appear *before* the predicate in English, and control agreement on the verb. If the subject is a pronoun, it is in nominative case (*I, we, you, he, she, it, they*)

Direct object

Objects usually appear *after* the verb in English. If the direct object is a pronoun, it is in accusative case (*me, us, you, him, her, it, them*)

Indirect object:

With ditransitive verbs, the indirect object is often the recipient of the direct object. The indirect object is often (but not always) marked by “to” or another preposition; in English, if the indirect object is a pronoun, it is in accusative case (but in languages that have dative case, indirect objects are often in dative case)

CLASSIFYING SENTENCES

Now that we've looked at grammatical terminology relating to predicates and arguments within sentences,

let's talk about terminology for sentences and clauses as a whole. First, we can classify them according to their **function**—whether they are used to make a statement, ask a question, or give a command.

Declarative

Declarative clauses are statements, things that can be true or false.

Interrogative

Interrogative clauses are questions. Questions come in two general types:

- Yes-No questions, like: *Did Romil watch a movie?*
and
- Content questions, like: *What did Romil watch?*

Imperative

Imperative clauses express requests or commands. For example: *Open the door (please)!*

Alternatively, we can classify sentences according to their **structure**; that is, according to whether they contain one clause or more than one clause, and (if more than one clause) how the sub-clauses are related to one other.

Simple sentence

A sentence is **simple** if it contains only one clause. All the sentences we have seen so far have been simple sentences.

Compound sentence

A **compound** sentence has at least two clauses, linked by a conjunction like *and*, *or*, or *but*. For example: *[Danai laughed] and [Seo-yeon cried]*.

Complex sentence

A **complex** sentence is one that contains a subordinate embedded clause—a clause inside a clause. This is an example of recursion! For example: *Seo-yeon knows [that Danai laughed]*.

Variation across languages: order of Subject, Object, and Verb

Having reviewed terminology relating to predicates and their arguments, we're now in a better position to talk about variation across languages in terms of basic word order—the order found in simple declarative clauses, in the absence of any special emphasis or topic.

English is **Subject-Verb-Object** (SVO). This is a very common basic word order; according to the [*World Atlas of Language Structures*](#) (Dryer, 2013), it is found in about 35.5% of the world's languages. Other languages

with this basic word order include ASL, both Mandarin and Cantonese, Nahuatl, and most of the Romance languages. (Even though not all clauses have objects, we still include objects when describing basic word orders; in a sentence without an object, the order for these languages would just be SV.)

The *most* common basic word order in the world is Subject-Object-Verb; this is found in 41% of languages, according to Dryer (2013). Japanese and Korean are both SOV languages, as are Turkish, Farsi, Hindi-Urdu, Malayalam, Amharic, and Haida.

But even though SVO and SOV are the two most common orders, all the other logically possible orders for subjects, objects, and verbs are also attested in the world's languages.

Basic Verb-Subject-Object order is found, for example, in Irish and the other Celtic languages, as well as in Anishinaabemowin and some other Algonquian languages. Orders where the object comes before the subject (VOS, OVS, OSV) are less common, but nonetheless found in a few languages.

As we noted before, however, even though most languages have a basic word order (the order found in neutral declarative sentences), in many languages this order is much more flexible than it is in English.

When a language's word order is flexible, it's usually the case that order determined at least partly by **topic** and/or **focus**; the topic is the thing you're talking about, and the focus is something you want to emphasize. So while English has a very strict SVO word order, languages with word order that is flexible with respect to the subject and predicate might be said to have a strict **topic-comment** word order, where the first element in the sentence is the **topic** (the thing the sentence is about) and the rest is a **comment** on that topic. Language users will often prefer or require particular word orders in particular conversational contexts.

In [Chapter 9.3](#) Dr. Kanatawakhon-Maracle gives several examples of flexible word order of this type in Mohawk (also known as Kanien'kéha)—showing that translating from English isn't always straightforward, with many different translations being possible with shades of meaning that can be a bit hard to distinguish in English.

Check your understanding



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Navigation

If you are following the alternative path through this chapter that interleaves core concepts with tree structures, this section comes after [6.1 Syntactic knowledge and grammaticality judgements](#), and the next section is [6.3 Phrases, Heads, and Selection](#).

References

Matthew S. Dryer. 2013. Order of Subject, Object and Verb. In: Dryer, Matthew S. & Haspelmath, Martin (eds.) *The World Atlas of Language Structures Online*. Leipzig: Max Planck Institute for Evolutionary Anthropology. (Available online at <http://wals.info/chapter/81>, Accessed on 2022-02-26.)

6.10 ARGUMENTS AND THEMATIC ROLES

Arguments as participants in events

In [Section 6.2](#) we classified predicates in terms of their **transitivity**—that is, the number of arguments they combine with. Intransitive verbs take only a subject, while transitive verbs take both a subject and an object, and ditransitive verbs take a subject, an object, and an indirect object.

Importantly, “subject” and “object” are **structural** terms, not semantic ones. In English, a subject appears at the beginning of a declarative clause, has nominative case (if it’s a pronoun), and controls agreement on the tensed verb. An object in English occurs after the verb, and has accusative case (if it’s a pronoun).

We might ask, though, whether all subjects are interpreted similarly, or if all objects are.

Looking towards semantics (the study of meaning), verbs can be thought of as describing **events** or **states**. The difference between events and situations, in semantics, is that events are often thought of as dynamic (things are actively happening), whereas states are static (things that are simply true, without anything happening, like *being tall*). From here on in this section we’ll use **eventuality** as a general term for both events and states.

An eventuality involves some number of **participants**. The participants in an eventuality can play various **roles**, which in linguistics are called **thematic roles**.

Do subjects always play the same **role** in an eventuality? If we look at the following examples, it looks like they don’t:

- | | | | |
|-----|----|------------------------------|--|
| (1) | a. | The children yelled. | (children did something on purpose) |
| | b. | The wind blew the tree down. | (wind did something, but not on purpose) |
| | c. | The tree burned. | (something happened to the tree) |

Indeed, we sometimes see this even with a single verb, as with *sink* in (2).

- | | | | |
|-----|----|---------------------------|---------------------------------------|
| (2) | a. | The pirate sank the ship. | (the pirate did something on purpose) |
| | b. | The ship sank. | (something happened to the ship) |

In the sentences in (2), we see that the verb *sink* can be either transitive or intransitive. In (2a) [*the pirate*] is the

subject and in (2b) [*the ship*] is the subject, but they play different roles in the eventuality. Indeed, in (2a) [*the ship*] is the *object*, but plays the same role in the eventuality as it does when it's the subject in (2b).

But for other verbs, we don't see this kind of "trading places":

- (3) a. The author wrote the book.
 b. The author wrote.

In (3) the subject stays the same in the transitive and intransitive uses of the verb *write*, and [*the author*] continues to play the same kind of role in the eventuality.

To talk about the different roles associated with subjects and objects, we can define a number of thematic roles that are relevant in natural language. There are potentially many such roles, but in this chapter we'll focus on just a few.

Agent:

Agents are animate actors who do things on purpose.

- [The pirate] sank the ship. (subject = agent)

Causer:

Causers are often inanimate (not alive); they cause things to happen but without acting on purpose.

- [The bilge pump malfunction] sank the ship. (subject = causer)

Not all animate subjects are agents: some animate subjects instead perceive something or experience a mental state.

Experiencer:

An experiencer is an animate participant that experiences a mental state. This includes perceiving something, as with the subjects of verbs like *see*, *hear*, etc.

- [Pirates] frighten **me**. (**me** = experiencer, [pirates] = causer)
- **I** fear [pirates]. / **I** like [pirates]. (**I** = experiencer, [pirates] = causer)
- [**The pirates**] saw an approaching storm. ([**the pirates**] = experiencer)

Theme:

The theme is the participant to which something happens, and may be changed by the event.

- The pirate sank [the ship]. ([the ship] = theme, affected/changed by the event)
- The author read [a book]. ([a book] = theme, not affected by the event)

Some work on thematic roles distinguishes **themes** (undergo an event, but are not affected or changed) from **patients** (undergo an event, and are affected or changed as a result). The objects of verbs of consumption (like *eat*) or creation (like *build*) are prototypical patients; they either disappear or come into existence as a result of the verb's action. The distinction between themes and patients is not relevant for our discussion here, though, and so we won't worry about it.

Instrument:

An instrument is the thing an agent uses to accomplish an action, often (but not necessarily) introduced in English by the preposition *with*.

- The pirate sank the ship [with a cannon]. (PP = instrument)

Location:

A location is the place where an eventuality occurs, often (but not necessarily) introduced by a locative preposition.

- The pirate sank the ship [at sea]. (PP = location)

Goal:

The goal is the location or person that receives the theme. In most ditransitives, the indirect object is the goal of the eventuality.

- The pirates sent [the ship] **a message**.
- The pirates sent **a message** to [the ship]. ([the ship] = goal; **a message** = theme)

Different verbs don't just select how *many* arguments they combine with, but also select what thematic roles those arguments take. At the same time, verbs aren't totally free to map thematic roles onto argument positions; for example, while we've seen that an experiencer can be either the subject or object of a verb, if a verb combines with both an agent and a theme, the agent is always the subject. Also, whenever a verb takes

only a single argument, that argument will necessarily be the subject (at least in English, and in many other languages).

Looking at verbs with only one argument, we find both **agent-intransitives** (intransitive verbs where the subject is an agent) and **theme-intransitives** (intransitive verbs where the subject is a theme) in English. (If we kept looking, we could also find intransitives whose single argument had other thematic roles as well, but these are the most common.)

(4) **Agent intransitives:**

- a. The pirate laughed.
- b. Everyone jumped.
- c. The author wrote.

(5) **Theme intransitives:**

- a. The tree fell.
- b. The ship sank.
- c. The ice melted.
- d. A train arrived.

Eventualities with no participants

Does every verb have to have at least one argument? Do all eventualities have at least one participant? In languages like English, every sentence has to have a pronounced subject (as long as the clause is finite and non-imperative). But consider sentences like the ones in (6):

- (6)
- a. It is raining.
 - b. It is snowing.

We might think that weather verbs like *rain*, *snow*, etc. take something like a theme subject—the *it* subject refers to something like “the weather”.

Pronouns like *it* can usually be replaced with full NPs, however, and yet it’s quite odd to replace the *it* subject of weather verbs with [*the sky*] or [*the weather*]:

- (7) a. #The sky is raining.
b. #The weather is snowing.

(Remember that marking a sentence with a hashmark indicates that it's grammatical but semantically odd.)

Thinking in terms of thematic roles gives us a handle on what's going on with this type of predicate: these are verbs that describe eventualities that don't have *any* participants. So when it's raining or snowing, then (at least in English) we don't describe that as being something that anything is *doing*, it's just something that happens.

Where does the *it* come from, then? One influential suggestion is that this *it* just shows up to give the sentence a subject, when there's no other subject available. (This is kind of like Do-Support, but for subject position.)

So a verb like *rain* or *snow* has one syntactic argument (a subject), but describes an eventuality with no participants.

Navigation

If you are following the alternative path through this chapter that interleaves core concepts with tree structures, the previous section was [6.19 Trees: Movement](#) and the next section is [6.11 Changing argument structure: Causatives and passives](#).

Check your understanding

Coming soon!

6.11 CHANGING ARGUMENT STRUCTURE: CAUSATIVES AND PASSIVES

So far we've only looked at thematic roles that verb roots come specified with. But all languages have ways to **adjust** the thematic roles expressed in a clause, either syntactically or morphologically.

Adding arguments: Causatives

For example, many languages have a **causative** construction. Causatives add an extra causer or agent (which becomes a new subject). English has several syntactic causative constructions, which we saw in [Section 5.7](#) in the context of causative morphology; the causative construction with the verb *make* is shown again in (1):

- (1) a. They read a book. (transitive: subject = agent, object = theme)
 b. **I made** them read a book. (causative: adds a second causer/agent)

Notice that in (1b) the original subject (*they*) appears after *make* and is in accusative case (*them*)—its structural position in the sentence changes in the causative construction, even though its thematic role stays the same.

Other languages have morphological causatives, that don't involve a causative verb like *make*, but instead have verbal morphology that does the same work of adding an additional causer argument. Japanese is a language with a morphological causative, illustrated in (2).

- (2) a. Neko-wa tabe-ta
 cat-TOPIC eat-PAST
 "The cat ate." (intransitive: subject = agent)
 b. Watasi-wa neko-ni tabe-sase-ta
 I-TOPIC cat-DAT eat-CAUS-PAST
 "I made the cat eat." (causative: adds a second causer/agent)

Like in English, the original subject from (2a) (*neko-wa*) takes on different case marking in the causative sentence in (2b) (*neko-ni*)—though in Japanese, the causee agent (the person or thing being made to do

something) is marked with dative case, rather than the accusative case we see in English. In many languages with both causatives and morphological case, causees end up marked as with either dative or accusative case.

There are many other argument adding constructions in natural languages. One other that we see in English are benefactive applicatives, which add a participant that the event is done *for*, usually as an indirect object. For example: *I baked a cake.* → *I baked **my friend** a cake.*

Removing arguments: Passives

Conversely, there are constructions that **remove** an argument from the ones the verb usually selects. Perhaps the most famous of these is the **passive**.

English, like many of the world's languages, has a passive construction, which removes the original subject of a verb, resulting in the original object becoming the passive subject. A non-passive sentence is known as an **active** sentence. For example:

- (3) a. They **wrote** a book. (original sentence: active)
 b. A book **was written** (by them). (passive)

A grammatical passive can be identified by the following three properties:

1. Original subject of the basic (active) transitive verb is demoted: it ceases to be the subject, and is **optionally** expressed in a propositional phrase (in English = *by* phrase) or in a noun phrase marked with specific case morphology.
2. Object of the basic (active) transitive verb becomes the **subject** of the passive clause.
3. Characteristic morphology or syntax (in English = *be* + Past Participle *-en/-ed*)

All three of these properties are needed for a clause to be a true grammatical passive. Active and passive are often referred to as grammatical **voices** (as in *active voice* or *passive voice*). Some languages have other grammatical voices, for example middle voice in Greek, but we will not discuss other voice constructions in this chapter.

The first property of passives relates them to corresponding active sentences. This is a key property of passives: for any passive clause, there is always an active counterpart. (This is similar to questions, which we described in terms of their grammatical relationship to statements.)

Consider the following active sentence:

- (4) The pirates sank the ship.

This is transitive, so it has a passive counterpart:

- (5) The ship was sunk (by the pirates).

The sentence in (5) has all three defining properties of passives:

1. The verb is replaced by *be* + past participle *sunk*
2. The original subject is demoted and appears in an optional *by-phrase*
3. The subject is [the ship], which was the theme object of the active verb.

Compare this with the theme-intransitive we saw in the previous section:

- (6) The ship sank (*by the pirates).

In contrast to (5), the sentence in (6) does **not** have all three defining properties of a grammatical passive:

1. The subject is [the ship], which was the theme object of the active verb, **but**
2. The original subject **cannot** be expressed in a *by-phrase*
3. There is **no** auxiliary *be*, and no past participle.

While the subject in both these cases is [the ship], the theme intransitive doesn't have the other properties of a passive clause.

Passives in Popular Discourse

In prescriptive grammar and in popular discussions, the passive has a bad reputation, and advice or “rules” for writing often says that you should avoid the passive entirely. Sometimes this is justified by saying that the passive “hides” the agent of an event.

In fact, though, the passive allows you to express the agent in a *by-phrase* in a way that other intransitives do not:

- | | | |
|--------|-----------------------------------|---|
| (7) a. | The ship was sunk by the pirates. | (Passive, but expresses the agent) |
| b. | The ship sank. | (Active! But no way to express who did the sinking) |
| c. | The bomb exploded. | (Active! But doesn't say who set the bomb) |

So the reason given for avoiding the passive doesn't hold up.

In both writing advice and in online discussions, you often see headlines criticized for using “passive voice” when they use verbs like “dies”/“died” or “something went wrong”, without identifying the cause of death or who did something wrong. This points out a problem with the *content* of various types of public language (headlines, public statements by politicians), but they frame the criticism in terms of *grammatical structure*.

This is an example of how *language ideologies*—our attitudes and beliefs about language—can be expressed in popular discourse. Here people express a legitimate criticism of public writing—that writers haven't clearly expressed the agent or person responsible for an action—but present that criticism as though it is a grammatical issue (and in a way that doesn't match the original grammatical meaning of the term “passive”). While there's nothing wrong with changing the meaning of the word “passive”—the meanings of words change all the time!—it's useful to be aware of its technical meaning as applied to grammatical structure.

Summary

All languages have ways of changing the pattern of arguments in a clause. Sometimes these changes involve special morphology on the verb or other elements in the sentence, but they always have syntactic effects: they might add or remove arguments, or change how those arguments appear (in terms of their structural position or their morphological marking, or both). Here we've looked at just a few examples—causatives and benefactive applicatives that add arguments, and passives that remove an argument—but languages can have many more. Think about whether any of the languages you know have similar constructions to the ones we've seen here, or if they have other ways of changing the pattern of arguments in a clause.

Check your understanding

Coming soon!

Navigation

If you are following the alternative path through this chapter that interleaves core concepts with tree structures, the previous section was [6.10 Arguments and thematic roles](#) and the next section is [6.20 Trees: Movement beyond questions](#), which discusses the structure of passives in terms of trees and movement.